A Dusk of Poison, An Antidote of Dawn

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by delta_altair

Summary

Mydei turned around, intending to survey how many Titankin were left and to taunt Phainon with his kill count.

Instead, his breath left him and a frigid cold rocketed through his veins.

Phainon stood next to a ruined wall, corpses of Titankin littering the ground around him. His greatsword was buried in the chest of a dying Titankin before him. But despite a second foe rapidly approaching him, Phainon had not yet removed his sword from the corpse. Sweat beaded at his brow, and even at a distance Mydei could tell that his breathing was labored. His hands left the hilt of his sword, and Phainon stared down at them. A mix of confusion and fatigue spread across his face. He stumbled, knees unsteady.

The Titankin behind Phainon raised its weapon.

Mydei had seen this once before. A great warrior brought to heel by some strange, unexplainable force, a fugue state descending upon them.

His mother.

Phainon is poisoned while fighting Titankin, and Mydei relives his worst nightmare. Injuries need tending, and confessions of the past and present are made.

Notes

Edit: From the 3.1 stream, we now have confirmation that the tale of Mydei being thrown into the sea when he was *very* young is the same event as his father trying to kill him, so Mydei proooobably wasn't old enough to remember his mother's battle. While my initial interpretation of his backstory is now non-canon, I hope you still enjoy!

See the end of the work for more notes

Dusk hung over the countryside. Not the natural kind now only found in children's storybooks, the gentle passage between day and night. This dusk was a terminator, the boundary of a clash between the Everlight of the holy city and the eternal night blanketing the rest of Amphoreus. Few who lived within Okhema ever saw it. The safe regions of the outskirts were still well within reach of the Dawn Device. Only those fleeing the destruction for the safety of Okhema, those foolish enough to leave the protection of Kephale's eternal dawn, and those tasked with pushing back the ever encroaching darkness would ever see it.

Mydei and Phainon were among the latter group. Sometimes, the agents of the black tide would push their luck. Roving bands of Titankin had been sighted on the plains between Okhema and Janusopolis, far larger than was typical so close to the holy city. Usually, the monsters that shambled out of Mydei's former home fled from the light of dawn like a morning mist. But sometimes they grew bold. Some lingering ember of the tenacity of Strife within them, perhaps.

The road connecting the two cities, which flowed over rolling hills once filled with grain and farms, was the primary route for refugees coming from beyond Janusopolis. It *must* be kept safe.

Hence his and Phainon's mission, to find and eliminate the group of Titankin. It was unusual for a pair of Chrysos Heirs to be deployed for such a simple objective. But the Titankin were numerous enough to be a danger to Okhema's defensive legion, and they were close enough to the city that the pair could be recalled quickly in the event of another crisis.

If asked whether Aglaea had *also* mentioned "furthering your teamwork" as part of her reasoning, then Mydei would have pleaded ignorance.

It was *fine,* of course. Phainon was an exceptionally strong fighter. No part of Mydei was loath to admit that. They worked well together. But he was used either leading from the front of an army, backed only by his Kremnoan brothers and sisters, or working alone.

Phainon had joined their Flame-Chase Journey a little over half a year ago. In that time, Phainon had transitioned from the hollow shell Mydei had first witnessed to the city's hero in short order. Mydei remembered, with a strange mix of ire and amusement, when Phainon had relentlessly needled Mydei on a myriad of topics until he stumbled onto their common interest in combat. Aglaea began pairing them on missions early on. The job would always get done, even if Phainon talked Mydei's ear off every time.

Yet today, Phainon was not talkative. Unusually quiet, even. As they made their way across the plains, Mydei had snuck more than a few glances at the other man — just to make sure that something wasn't wrong, Mydei would tell himself — and he saw that same hollow, far-off look in Phainon's eyes from when they had first met.

Perhaps he should ask. The reprieve from Phainon's typical jests and teases would be welcome, but not if something was wrong. But Mydei was not used to asking if people were *alright,* and especially not Phainon. Conversations between the two of them were plentiful, but had all the depth of a fountain.

Locked in his thoughts, Mydei had forgotten to stop staring at Phainon. It was too late when Phainon's icy blue gaze caught him. In an instant Phainon flashed a quick grin, that hero's smile, and opened his mouth to speak.

Mydei scoffed and looked away. There we go.

"I've read in Okhema's records that Castrum Kremnos had a normal cycle of day and night for much longer than the rest of the outer cities. Is that true?"

An innocent enough question, Mydei supposed. "Yes. With the movement afforded to the entire city, for a time Kremnos was shifted between the outer border of Okhema and further out to the rest of the world. The warriors defending the city were strong enough to hold against any incursions, so that the people could live normally." He remembers the first time he had joined the night guard, how young he was. An honor, for the young prince. "But only when I was young."

He spied Phainon's expression change out of the corner of his vision. His bold smile shifted to something softer. A pleased little quirk to his lips, as if Phainon had won something by learning that tidbit of Mydei's past.

Mydei sighed to himself. Doubtless a hurricane of questions was now about to descend upon him. But at least Phainon no longer looked like a wandering ghost.

Though Mydei was not sure why he cared.

But the questions did not come.

"There they are," Phainon declared.

They had just crested a ridge. Below them, nestled in the natural valley between low hills, lay the ruins of a small village. In its prime it could only have been home to no more than a dozen people, probably all farmers. Now it was but a ruin. An open scar on the world, a reminder of what had been lost to the black tide. At the village edge, several Titankin stood watch. Deeper within, Mydei spied movement among the ruined buildings.

Phainon hefted his broadsword up onto his shoulder, and glanced at Mydei. A raised eyebrow was a question Mydei understood completely.

"What's the prize this time?" Mydei asked, now grinning himself.

"Hmm…." Phainon narrowed his eyes, deep in thought, before he lit up again with a bright smile. "That bookshop we visited last week. We were summoned away before we could really browse that much. Something from there?"

"I accept your challenge, Deliverer. May the best warrior win."

Whatever the invisible ridge of tension was that caused the ephemeral distance between himself and Phainon in their casual moments, it did not exist in battle. In the blind fury of combat, together they were unstoppable.

It had not been without some hiccups early on. It took Phainon some time to acclimate to Mydei's unorthodox fighting style. Mydei's undying curse and Phainon's unshakable heroism mixed like oil and water on their first outings. But Phainon was a quick learner, and soon enough they fell into a comfortable rhythm.

Mydei in the center of the fray, a whirlwind of blood, metal, and chaos. He was a bomb thrown into whatever formation their enemies had kept, shattering their resolve like glass upon rock.

That would leave the rest of the field wide open for his battle partner. Phainon fought like no other Mydei had ever witnessed. There was the unmistakable aura of heroism that followed Phainon even in battle. A certain elegance as he weaved between attacks and struck down foes left and right. But underneath it all, Mydei could sense that same brutality, that same focused rage he harnessed himself.

Phainon annihilated anything that chose not to engage with Mydei face-to-face. It worked well. Mydei had no time for cowards. Any Titankin that would attempt to sneak up behind Mydei's back, or attack him from range, would inevitably be cut down.

With Phainon at his side, Mydei would often leave combat with no wounds at all to speak of. No painful lacerations on his back, no arrows to rip out. Though he would never shy away from using his immortality to win victory, it was…refreshing.

Not that he would ever tell this to Phainon.

Firstly, lest he be the direct target of Phainon's insufferable fawning. It was bad enough when Mydei had first told him that he was a strong warrior. The questions had only ceased when Mydei agreed to spar with him.

Second, sometimes Phainon's heroism was dangerous. Too many times Mydei had witnessed him put himself deep under the shadow of Thanatos' hand to save others. In the case of civilians, that was their duty, even though Mydei had attempted many times to drill the fact that he was immortal and thus the best choice for dangerous tactics through Phainon's thick skull, to little avail. But the savior complex had at least not extended to Mydei himself. He hoped it never would.

What they had together worked well. Today was no different.

Or so he had thought.

“Fifteen!” Mydei roared as he cleaved another Titankin in half, shoulder to hip. His gauntlets were stained with the golden ichor of Nikador. This was a good fight.

Beyond the din of combat surrounding him, he heard Phainon’s count of ‘twelve’ in the distance. Hah. Impressive, but slower than him as usual. He had been vanquishing Titankin with impressive speed, though there was an archer further back that had been harassing both of them. Mydei assumed Phainon would deal with it soon.

A Titankin, one of the larger ones, charged at Mydei, brandishing a spear.

Mydei charged in kind, gauntlets up and ready to wrest the spear from his enemy’s hands.

Just as he made contact with the Titankin, on Mydei’s left, a crumbling wall shattered with the force of another Titankin barreling through it. It lunged straight for him.

His hands were occupied with the spear of his current foe. If he moved, he’d leave himself open to a far worse attack. He’d take the hit, then. His wounds would be healed by the time they made it to the village center.

Mydei tucked his head behind his pauldron and braced for the impact.

It never came.

Instead he felt a touch, so soft he could have imagined it, brush across his back.

And then the familiar sound of Phainon’s broadsword striking iron.

That *fool!*

One Titankin Phainon obviously could handle, but now he was out of formation, and that archer—

A new shock of adrenaline flooded through him. With a sharp yank, the Titankin stumbled forward and lost its grip on its spear. Not bothering to flip the sharp end around, Mydei drove the blunt end of the golden spear through the Titankin’s chest. Ichor spurted out of the wound, coating the grass beneath them a shiny metallic.

Mydei was about to rip the spear out to throw when he heard it. The sharp *whizz* of an arrow, a pained gasp. The arrow impacted the ground ahead of Mydei, tip burying into the ground. It carried with it a small scrap of white fabric.

In a split second, Mydei wrapped his hand around the neck of the slain Titankin. Metal strained, rock splintered, the tips of his gauntlets carved deep into its head, leaving channels of golden ichor in their wake. Then, a release. Mydei whirled around, taking only a second to locate the archer, its bow still up and drawn. He hurled the head of the dead Titankin with all his might. The impact was brutal. The archer exploded into pieces with the force of it. What was left of its carcass fell to the ground in a slump.

Mydei let out the breath he had been holding. Then his gaze shifted to his right, and found Phainon.

Phainon, who was staring at Mydei, eyes wide and mouth slightly agape, like some child at the opera. His left hand was pressed to his side, high up on his ribcage, just underneath his arm. But no golden blood seeped from between his fingers, as Mydei had feared.

Fear? Yes, he realized, it was fear that had just driven him.

Fear that was quickly draining away, however, leaving anger in its wake.

"That was," Phainon started, eyes still wide. "Uh, incredible? How did you—"

"How *often* do you need such simple commands repeated to you, *Deliverer?"* Mydei nearly spat the epithet.

Phainon blinked, momentarily taken aback, but his gaze quickly narrowed. "I was helping you, aren't we—"

"I don't need your *help,"* Mydei snarled. "My duty is to take those hits. What were you thinking?!"

The pain laden in Phainon's expression didn't leave. It only got worse. "You're too self-sacrificing Mydei." *Oh,* Mydei had a *sharp* rebuttal for that concept, but Phainon soldiered on too quickly. "We're part of a team, we're supposed to be relying on each other."

"Perhaps in your books, Deliverer, but you ignore the *reality* of our situation." Already, they were arguing in circles. This was a conversation they'd had too many times.

Phainon glanced away, though frustration was still plain on his face. "…well the reality is that there are still more Titankin in the village who probably heard all that fighting. We need to move."

He walked past Mydei. Hand still pressed to his side.

"Wait." Mydei reached out, but Phainon was already beyond his reach. "Your wound. You should tend to it first."

"It's nothing," Phainon said quickly, lowering his arm. Mydei could see the small tear in his coat, but the shadow of his arm concealed any details. "We don't have time for that. And besides…." Phainon hefted his greatsword onto his shoulder once again and glanced back at Mydei. That familiar smirk graced his features again. "I need to beat you."

A ridiculous mix of emotions flared in Mydei's chest. It was mostly irritation. Mostly. But hidden among it was something soft. A twinge of affection.

Absurd.

With a huff, Mydei marched forward. "Very well. I trust you to know your own limits."

That he could do. Phainon was no liar. But much later, Mydei would curse himself for not checking the arrow, for not pulling it out of the ground to see what coated that arrowhead besides dirt and golden blood.

They met the group of Titankin, larger than what had been posted at the village edge, in the center of town. Or what was left of it. The central plaza was surrounded by larger buildings, most of them in utter disrepair.

Mydei fell back into his familiar rhythm quickly enough. The Titankin had been waiting for helpless refugees to seek shelter in the ruins, not for the specter of Strife itself to come calling. Phainon had obeyed Mydei's demands, or at least had taken them somewhat to heart. When Mydei glanced his way, Phainon was still cutting down Titankin with ferocious efficiency, but he held a more defensible position. Good.

He took down two Titankin at once, having plunged his armor-clad arm through the chest of one to crush the neck of another. They collapsed in a heap before him. Those had been the last Titankin in Mydei's corner of the square, and brought him to an even forty.

Mydei turned around, intending to survey how many Titankin were left and to taunt Phainon with his kill count.

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Mydei moved faster than the next memory could reach him.

A discarded spear on the ground. Into his hand, hurled. A crash of metal, the Titankin split in twain.

Phainon barely reacted, only a soft jerk of his head away from the impact. His knees buckled beneath him. Another Titankin was encroaching, and a dozen more were close behind.

Mydei made it just as Phainon's strength left him. He collapsed into Mydei's chest, limp. Mydei wrapped an arm around his waist and held him close. With his other hand, Mydei grabbed the hilt of Phainon's sword. One handed, he heaved it over his shoulder and flung it.

Not his best throw, but it didn't matter. It took the nearest Titankin completely by surprise, smashing it to bits.

It would be a short reprieve before the rest of the Titankin descended upon them. Mydei knelt and gently, oh so gently laid Phainon onto the ground. He doesn't dare look, lest the nightmares that rattle in his mind at night spring to life and somehow, impossibly, he'd find that a kingly Kremnoan spear had pierced Phainon's heart.

Mydei stood. Rage boiling in his veins, his focus narrowed to a single point. Obliterate every Titankin.

He did so with ease, despite locking his position to stand over Phainon, protecting him from any harm. He'd taken on far worse odds before, and the Titankin did little to take advantage of Mydei's entrenched position. Mydei lost count after the first four fell to his fists. After that, it was a systematic slaughter. Every Titankin that dared to get near him was utterly torn apart.

Finally, silence fell as the last Titankin crumbled. Mydei let himself breathe for a few moments more, before steeling his heart and looking down.

Phainon stared back up at him. He was as pale as a ghost, but the look of awe in his eyes was familiar.

Relief flooded through Mydei, so strong it could have brought him to his knees. Like a sword being quenched in water, it shocked him out of his battle haze. Mydei stepped back and knelt at Phainon's side. He reached out and curled a hand around Phainon's shoulder, at the base of his neck.

Cold and clammy, but alive.

Phainon smiled. Not the cocky grin Mydei was used to, nor the facade of a smile he gave to the public. A real one. Mydei didn't know how he knew that. Only that he was sure.

"M-Mydei, that was—" Phainon all but wheezed the few words out before a hacking cough wracked over him.

"Quiet," Mydei said, firm but venomless. They weren't out of the woods yet. He slid an arm each under Phainon's legs and back and scooped him up. In any other situation, Mydei would have teased Phainon for the yelp the man let out upon being lifted into the air.

One of the former houses in the square was less dilapidated than the others. Mydei entered the ruin and set Phainon down. He unstrapped his gauntlets, drenched with Titankin blood, and placed them to the side. Finally, he lifted Phainon's left arm, gently, and looked at the wound.

It was extremely shallow, a mere glancing blow. The arrow had cut through Phainon's coat and shirt, but the injury itself looked no worse than a scrape. Phainon would have walked it off easily, Mydei thought, had it not been for the sickly green fluid around the edges of the wound that mixed with slowly seeping golden blood.

He was familiar with this poison. A mild paralytic when ingested or introduced into the bloodstream with enough concentration. Not lethal, especially not in the amount Phainon had gotten. But enough to cause dizziness, disorientation, and then a lingering lethargy. Enough to break the focus of a warrior. Enough to change the tide of a battle, if they were fighting alone.

Just like his mother.

He didn't realize his hands were trembling until Phainon's right hand slid over his own on Phainon's chest.

"Hey." He still sounded terrible, voice cracking. "Mydei. Look at me."

Mydei looked up. Phainon was craning his neck forward to look at Mydei. Still pale, clammy, the second worst Mydei had ever seen him. But his brows were drawn together, and he was frowning ever so slightly.

Phainon was *concerned.* For *him.*

It shocked him out of his haze instantly.

"It should be cleaned. I'll do it," Mydei said in a rush. He grabbed the small emergency pack he kept on his belt, courtesy of Lady Hyacine.

He busied himself with taking out the contents of the pack. Ignoring Phainon's mildly agitated whine of his name, his finger poking into Mydei's bicep. Ignoring the heat rising in his own face.

"Mydei, listen to me, I'm alri—h-hey!"

Phainon's complaints ground to a sharp halt as Mydei straddled his waist and hiked up his shirt, high enough to uncover the wound. Phainon grew still, both arms now resting next to his head.

"Let me work," Mydei muttered.

As he set to cleaning the wound, Mydei noticed in the periphery of his vision that Phainon's face had gone from as pale as ash to brilliantly flushed. Perhaps an effect of the poison fading, Mydei told himself — *Idiot, he would tell himself later* — a sign that Phainon was improving. Good. Once the wound was cleaned of poison, he packed it with healing herbs, just like Lady Hyacine had instructed him.

He'd gone to her once, asking to be taught. It made little sense, of course. He was undying, immortal. But she hadn't questioned him at all. Maybe she had seen right through him.

Just the bandage left. He slid his hand under Phainon's lower back and lifted to wrap the bandage around him. On an utterly foolish impulse, he stole a glance up at Phainon. Arms still nestled into the grass above his head. Snowy hair spilling across the ground, a winter halo. Face still flushed, eyes half lidded, staring right at Mydei. *Beautiful.* In an instant Mydei

looked away, swallowing. He didn't know if he regretted the look or not. Titans-damnit, *focus*.

Once he was satisfied with the stability of the bandage, he pulled Phainon's shirt back down. Phainon finally moved his arms then, straightening out the collar of his coat.

"Thank you," Phainon all but whispered.

Mydei grunted in response. He swallowed again before finally speaking. "Tribbie should come after us soon, we're late now as it is. We can wait here—"

He had begun to move off of Phainon, but the other man reached down and grabbed his thigh. Mydei froze.

"Are you going to listen to me now?"

He dropped his knee back down with a thump. He glared at Phainon, whose eyes now seemed clear once again.

"What is *wrong with you?"* Mydei hissed.

"So that's a no."

"Deliverer!" He didn't yell. His frustration spilled out of him in a sharp growl instead.

Phainon stared at him, expression unreadable. His hand left Mydei's thigh and grasped his hand instead. Mydei flinched at that, trying to pull back, but Phainon held surprisingly firm, given the poison. He was so strong.

Mydei glanced away, no longer able to hold the look in Phainon's eyes. "I do not understand you."

"Mydei mistakes happen. And we're allies. We watch each other's backs."

"I am the *undying,* it is my duty to—"

"No."

Mydei scowled. "You obstinate fool, you have witnessed my curse with your own eyes—"

"I'm tired, Mydei."

Mydei looked back at Phainon, who himself was now looking away. Over to the broken wall, out to the dusk-lit fields. His eyes looked a little unfocused.

An ember of panic relights within Mydei again. He leans forward. "Is the poison….?"

"Huh?" Phainon looked back at Mydei. "Oh, no, no, sorry. I'm alright. The dizziness is gone. I just…." He looked outside again. "I grew up in a place like this."

Mydei remained silent. He had never visited Aedes Elysiae, first only ever seeing it upon his father's maps when he was young. A small village, far in the countryside, inconsequential. After he had first met Phainon, and heard the hollow crack in his voice when he proclaimed his heritage, Mydei had looked it up within the Okheman archives. A small village, far in the countryside, obliterated by the black tide. He squeezed Phainon's hand. Consequential.

Phainon looked back up at Mydei. The corner of his lips tweaked up. A sad smile. "I guess I'm just tired of seeing bad things happen to the people I care about."

An assumption he had made of Phainon early on, in light of his reaction to the first time Mydei had died in front of him, an assumption of a weak heart and savior complex, melted away like a spring snow. Left in its wake was something small and precious. Mydei let out a breath he didn't realize he'd been holding. With it, he felt as if some part of his heart had detached itself from his chest and had run away from him.

Not that he wanted to stop it.

Beneath him, a shiver coursed through Phainon's body. Phainon let out a quiet groan.

Right, a chill was a common aftereffect of the poison.

Mydei would investigate the strange feeling in his own chest later. Though he was fairly certain he knew what it meant.

"The chill is normal. It will pass." He moved to Phainon's side and gently hoisted the other man up. "The Titankin are all vanquished. We'll leave once you're ready." Leaning against the wall behind Phainon's head, the sturdiest looking, he pulled Phainon back until he was resting against his chest. He suppressed an amused chuckle when Phainon let out a pleased hum and practically melted into him.

They were silent for a while. Mydei felt Phainon's steady breathing against his own chest. It felt good. Because it meant Phainon was healthy, unburdened by the poison? Yes. He thought so.

More than that? ….perhaps.

Phainon broke the silence first. "I'm sorry I worried you."

Mydei huffed out a laugh. "Why apologize for something you know you'll do again?"

He felt Phainon scowl against his shoulder. Cute. "We're still partners. I'm still going to look out for you in battle. I just meant…you seemed…very worried."

Indeed, he had been. Mydei felt an anchor of reluctance weighing on his tongue. It was not something he spoke of. But Phainon had shared something so personal with him, so….

"Poison took my mother from me."

Phainon jolted. His head tilted up in a snap, eyes wide behind his bangs. His mouth was open slightly in a silent gasp. He didn't speak.

Mydei swallowed, took a breath, then continued. “When the king…my father, was told of the prophecy of my future, of my predestined killing of both him and Nikador, he ordered my death. My mother challenged him to gladiatorial combat in my defense.” This Phainon likely knew of already through the whispers, half rumor and half fact, that followed Mydei. But only a scant few knew the truth. “She was more than his match,” Mydei declared, a defiant statement for the ghosts of the past. “They were evenly skilled, but she was fighting with the most potent rage within her blood driving her to glorious victory. A mother protecting her child. My father would have stood no chance. And he knew it.” Mydei curled his hand, the one that wasn’t draped over Phainon’s waist, into a fist. “The madness that had begun to take Nikador had taken him as well. Tainted his honor. A healer who joined my cause months later confirmed it, but I knew the moment I saw my mother falter that she had been poisoned. And I could do nothing.”

Phainon let out a shaky breath. “…I…I’m so sor—”

“If you pity me,” Mydei said, voice flat, glancing down at Phainon. “I will throw you through the wall.”

Phainon pouted. Mydei had to fight to keep his firmly neutral expression intact. Perhaps that had been unfair of him, but he needed the levity of Phainon’s benign irritation to quench the pain in his heart.

“It’s not pity. I’m saying I’m sorry because I didn’t know the arrow was poisoned,” Phainon clarified. “And I didn’t know…I didn’t *know.”*

Mydei sighed, then spoke quietly, barely above a whisper. “You couldn’t have known.”

It was a poor apology. He would give Phainon a proper one, once they had returned to Okhema and his head was clearer.

Something about the way Phainon leaned his head back on Mydei’s shoulder and nestled closer made Mydei feel like his half-apology had been accepted, though.

They rested in silence for a while longer. Mydei felt Phainon flexing his fingers against his stomach, urging the feeling back into them.

“You make for a good hearth,” Phainon remarked out of nowhere.

Mydei laughed at that. Not too hard, as to not jostle Phainon around, but a real laugh. “Truly I’m thrilled that this *‘conspicuous body of mine’* can serve you so well.”

He was glancing down as he said it, and his grin only grew wider as he saw just how furiously red Phainon’s ears had turned. Oh it was far too easy and far too gratifying to tease him. Mydei leaned his head back against the wall.

“Hah!” Phainon laughed nervously, “Haha, you have it backwards, surely. You don’t serve anyone, right? You’re the prince.”

“Hm, indeed. And you, the country boy with no etiquette or decorum to speak of.”

Phainon's laugh was warm, airy, familiar in some impossible way.

Mydei felt Phainon push himself up straight. His strength must have fully returned, good.

He tilted his head back down, only to be met with Phainon at eye level. So close their noses were almost brushing.

The haze of poison had left Phainon's eyes completely. Left in its wake was something else, something Mydei couldn't quite identify. Some ephemeral mix of nerves, eagerness…

The corner of Phainon's lip quirked up in a tiny smirk. Mydei's eyes dropped to it.

"You're right," Phainon whispered. "No decorum. None at all…"

A moment passed. Tension coiled in Mydei's chest.

Then, outside, a sharp fizzle of magic. A cry, "Snowy!? De!??"

Phainon pulled back, and something in Mydei's chest *hurt* at that. What in the hells was wrong with him?

But then he caught Phainon's gaze once more, and his nerves stilled at the other man's smirk, almost casual, and glint in his eyes.

"Suppose I should make sure I'm completely healed, *first,"* he all but drawled, and then it was Mydei's turn to have his ears go blood red.

Mercifully, Phainon called out, as Mydei found his voice suddenly not working.

"We're in here Tribbie! We're alright."

The rooftops over Marmoreal Market were the perfect balance of intrigue and peace. Mydei could observe the goings-on of the city as he pleased, but wasn't beholden to random interruptions to his day. Few others knew how to get to this particular overhang, and fewer still had the audacity to interrupt his repose.

Mydei was leaning back against the curved wall of the building next to the roof, eyes closed, enjoying Kephale's dawn, when he heard footsteps coming across the bridge to the roof.

The right kind of audacity would be welcome enough, though.

"Good morning Mydei." Phainon sounded chipper. Good. It had only been a day since they had returned from outside the city.

Mydei was about to respond when a shadow fell across his closed eyes. He frowned. Perhaps a little too audacious?

He opened his eyes, and then his mouth to complain about Phainon blocking his light, but froze.

Phainon stood before him, arms behind his back, leaning forward ever-so-slightly into Mydei's space. He eclipsed the Dawn Device completely. His white hair caught in the golden light like a halo. Dawn caressed his features like silk. He was radiant. Handsome. Mydei felt both his breath and his irritation slipping away like sand between his fingers.

Ah. Alright then.

Phainon quirked an eyebrow at Mydei's hesitation, then brought his arms out from behind his back. In one hand, he held a book. "For you. Your victory prize."

Mydei took the tome. It was a book of poetry, the efforts of a Kremnoan and Janusopolan historian pair who worked together to piece together records of old poems from a time of great cultural exchange between the two cities.

Mydei thumbed over the embossed title on the cover. He had been looking at this one when he and Phainon had visited that bookshop.

"You're perceptive."

Phainon smiled. "When it's important."

Something in Mydei's brain, and his heart, settled.

"My thanks, Phainon." He pretended not to notice the way Phainon's eyes widened at Mydei saying his name. As he gently placed the book down to the side, Mydei asked, "And your injury?"

"Ah, I've received a clean bill of health from our dear Lady Hyacine." Phainon pulled the side of his coat back and patted his ribs. "Hardly even sore."

He was looking down at his chest, distracted. Perfect.

Mydei shot a hand out, snagged a finger under the strap securing Phainon's pauldron, and yanked.

Phainon landed on top of Mydei, body settling into the curve of the wall as Mydei's was. It was a soft landing. Mydei had neglected to wear his heavy armor today.

Despite blushing, *hard,* Phainon grinned and let out a sly chuckle. "Eager, are we?"

Mydei hummed. He slid his hand down Phainon's side, then swiped gently at the hem of his shirt.

He waited.

Phainon smiled, then nodded.

Mydei relished the feel of Phainon's muscles twitching as he slid his hand up under Phainon's shirt. But first…

The wound was healing well. Mydei could barely even feel a scar there. He brushed his thumb over it, and whispered, "Good."

Phainon's expression shifted slightly. The same heat, but tempered by a softness.

They held each other's gaze for another breathless moment, then Phainon leaned in and finally, *finally* kissed him.

Sweet, and a bit timid. Slow. The second less so. More heat, a shuddering breath, and Mydei knew he was well and truly enraptured.

They'd move from the rooftop quickly enough. The tiles digging into Mydei's back were not comfortable. But every time Mydei relaxed on that rooftop, basking in the dawn, he was reminded of that first kiss. Sometimes Phainon would aid in that remembering. And sometimes Mydei would be alone, reading his book, and he'd look down into the marketplace below and spy a familiar figure amongst the crowd. One who knew exactly when to turn and look up, and throw Mydei a smile as beautiful as the dawn light.

End Notes

So these two have a deathgrip on me. I have four other fic ideas in the works for them. Good job HYV, whatever you put into these blorbos is the real deal!

Thank YOU so much for reading!! I hope you enjoyed <3!

Also, the back ‘wall’ of the roof Mydei stands on really does curve in like that, I didn’t just make it up for this fic haha.

Edit: Apologies to anyone who read this early and noticed the tense change from past to present for a few lines around the middle! I've now fixed it.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!